OurMocks

2027 CYCLE

MOCK · PRACTICE · CRACK

CUET UG

History

Political and Economic Systems in Early States: Inscriptional Evidences

Themes in Indian History (Part I) · Theme 2 · Class 12

INSIDE
Concept Notes

INSIDE
Solved Examples

INSIDE
Practice MCQs + Solutions

Aligned to the latest official syllabus · Concept-first explanations

www.ourmocks.com

Syllabus Alignment

Sub-topic	Official syllabus pointer (NTA History 314)	Skills the questions test
The 6th Century BCE Watershed	Major political and economic developments c. 600 BCE to 600 CE; sixteen mahajanapadas; rise of Magadha	Fact recall, geographic identification of capitals and republics
The Mauryan Empire	Mauryan administration; Ashokan edicts, Dhamma, and Megasthenes' account of statecraft	Institutional decomposition, committee roles, epigraphic analysis
Divine Kingship & Regional States	New notions of kingship: Kushana divine status, Gupta prashastis, and South Indian chiefdoms	Comparative analysis of political legitimization
Agrarian Economy & Land Grants	Changing countryside; agricultural technologies; land grants (agrahara) and women's property rights	Social-economic causality, legal interpretation
Towns, Trade & Numismatics	Urban centres, merchant guilds (**shrenis**), and punch-marked to gold coins	Economic linkages, trade geography, numismatic history
Epigraphy & Decipherment	Decipherment of Brahmi and Kharosthi by James Prinsep; limitations of inscriptional evidence	Methodological critique, source evaluation

CUET Strategy & Exam Reality

- **Official Blueprint:** NTA History (Code 314) tests **Themes in Indian History Part I, Chapter 2**. Questions heavily focus on exact names of rulers, inscriptional titles (**Devanampiya Piyadassi**), locations of rock and pillar edicts, guild terminology (**shrenis**), and the sequence of numismatic issues.
- **Scoring Reality:** 50 questions are provided in CUET UG, out of which candidates must attempt 40. High-scoring candidates treat epigraphic terminology (e.g., **agrahara**, **tamrapatra**, **prashasti**) with precision.

1. The 6th Century BCE Watershed & The 16 Mahajanapadas

Why is the 6th century BCE universally celebrated as the great turning point in early Indian history?

The emergence of early states was not an isolated political event; it was driven by deep technological and socio-economic revolutions across northern India:

- **Second Urbanization:** Following the decline of the Bronze Age Harappan civilization more than a millennium earlier, cities re-emerged along the fertile Gangetic plain.

- **Iron Metallurgy:** The widespread adoption of iron axes allowed dense monsoon forests of the middle Ganga valley to be cleared for permanent agriculture, while iron-tipped ploughshares doubled agricultural yield.
- **Monetized Economy:** The introduction of standardized punch-marked coinage (**kahapana**) of silver and copper liberated commerce from traditional barter.
- **Heterodox Religious Ferment:** Sixty-two distinct philosophical schools arose, most notably Buddhism led by Gautama Buddha and Jainism systematized by Vardhamana Mahavira, both rejecting animal sacrifice and rigid Vedic ritualism.
- **Compilation of Dharmasutras:** Brahmanas composed normative Sanskrit legal manuals establishing royal duties, social stratification, and taxation guidelines, formally recommending kings collect one-sixth (**shadbhaga**) of agricultural produce as royal dues.

The Political Landscape: Monarchies vs Republics

Early Buddhist (**Anguttara Nikaya**) and Jaina texts enumerate sixteen great states (**Mahajanapadas**). While lists vary slightly, core states appear consistently:

Mahajanapada	Capital City	Key Historical & Political Feature
Magadha	Rajagriha / Pataliputra	Most powerful monarchy; controlled iron mines, elephant forests, and riverine trade routes.
Kosala	Shravasti	Major northern monarchy along the Sarayu river; prominent in Buddhist narratives.
Vatsa	Kaushambi	Flourishing trade node at the Yamuna junction ruled by King Udayana.
Avanti	Ujjayini / Mahishmati	Western kingdom controlling routes to Arabian Sea ports; fierce rival of early Magadha.
Gandhara	Taxila	North-western commercial gateway and major centre of higher learning.
Kamboja	Rajapura	Renowned for breeding superior war-horses in the far north-west.
Vajji	Vaishali	Famous confederacy of eight oligarchic clans (**sangha**), including the Licchavis.
Malla	Kusinara / Pava	Republican clan in whose twin capitals Buddha and Mahavira achieved death/liberation.

- **Ganas and Sanghas:** Unlike centralized monarchies where power resided in a single hereditary ruler, states like **Vajji** were oligarchies where power was shared collectively by a group of men titled **rajas**. Both Mahavira and Gautama Buddha belonged to such republican clans (Jnatrika and Shakya respectively).

2. The Rise of Magadha to Imperial Prominence

Between the 6th and 4th centuries BCE, Magadha (modern south Bihar) emerged as the most formidable power in the subcontinent. Why did Magadha triumph over all other Mahajanapadas?

Historians point to four interrelated structural factors:

- **Agricultural Fertility:** Magadha occupied the exceptionally fertile alluvial tracts of the middle Ganga valley, where regular rainfall and seasonal floods guaranteed high crop yields.
- **Mineral Riches:** Thick deposits of iron ore in the forested hills of modern Jharkhand (Singhbhum and Barabar) provided accessible raw materials to forge deadly weapons and agricultural implements.
- **Forest Wealth and War Elephants:** Dense eastern forests harboured wild elephants, an indispensable arm of the Magadhan military that could breach timber palisades and smash cavalry lines.
- **Water Communications:** The Ganga, Son, and Gandak rivers provided cheap, fast water transport for armies and merchant flotillas, far quicker than bullock-cart roads.

Dynastic Evolution of Magadha

Magadha's imperial ascent was steered by ambitious, ruthless dynasties:

1. **Haryanka Dynasty:**
   - **Bimbisara (c. 544–492 BCE):** Consolidated power through matrimonial alliances with Kosala and Vaishali, and conquered the maritime kingdom of Anga.
   - **Ajatasattu (c. 492–460 BCE):** Deposed and starved his father; utilized innovative siege weapons (**mahashilakantaka** catapult and **rathamusala** scythed chariot) to conquer the Vajji confederacy after a 16-year war.
2. **Shishunaga Dynasty:** Subdued the formidable kingdom of Avanti, ending a century-long Magadha-Avanti rivalry.
3. **Nanda Dynasty:** Founded by **Mahapadma Nanda**, who annexed central India and built an enormous standing army that terrified Alexander the Great's advancing Greek legions at the Beas river in 326 BCE.

The Strategic Capitals of Magadha

- **Rajagriha:** The earliest capital was Rajagriha ("house of the king"), modern Rajgir in Bihar. It was a natural mountain fortress completely ringed by five jagged stone hills, rendering it virtually impregnable to ancient siege warfare.
- **Shift to Pataliputra:** In the 4th century BCE, Magadhan kings shifted their administrative hub downriver to **Pataliputra** (modern Patna). Situated directly at the confluence of the Ganga and Son rivers, Pataliputra commanded commanding control over water-borne trade and long-distance troop movements.

3. The Mauryan Empire: Central Power, Administration & Military

In 321 BCE, **Chandragupta Maurya**, guided by his mentor **Chanakya** (Kautilya), overthrew Dhana Nanda and founded the Mauryan Empire, extending pan-Indian control from Bengal to Afghanistan and Baluchistan.

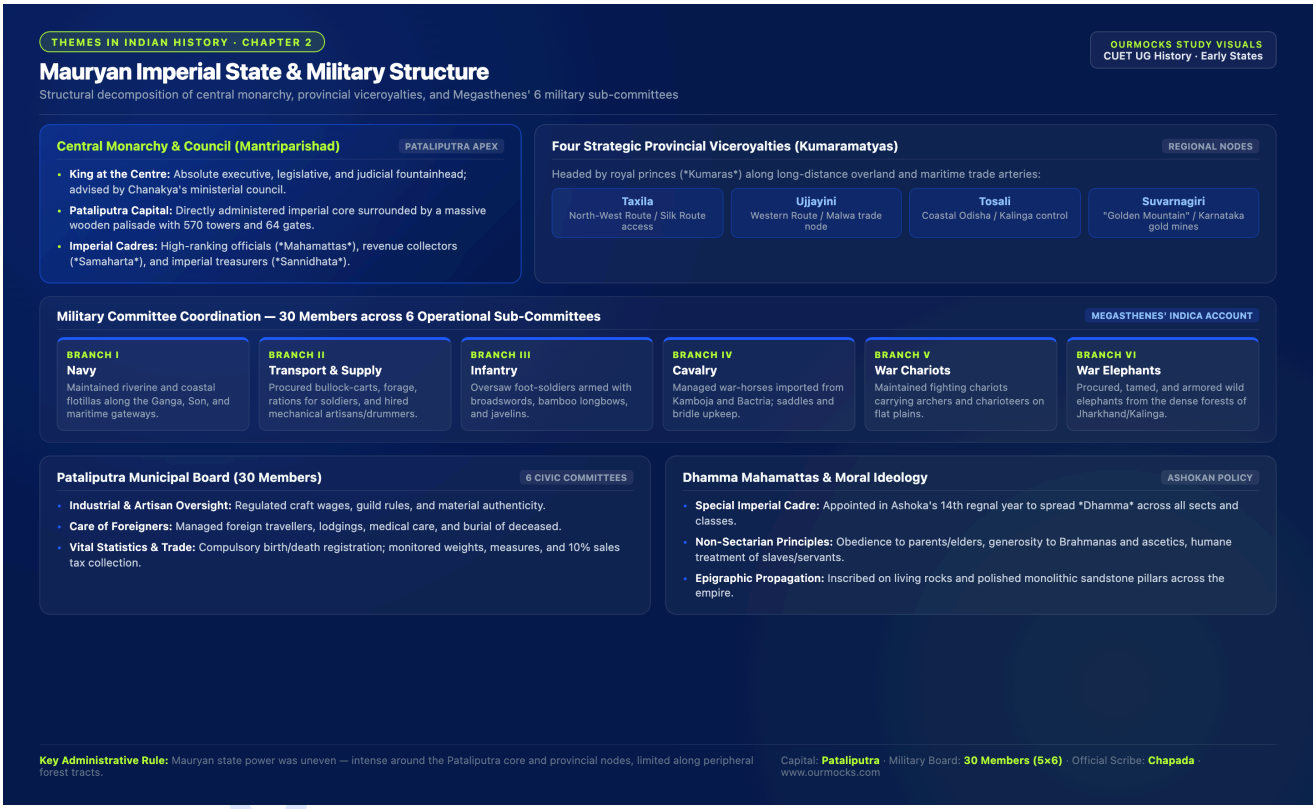


Figure 1: Figure 1 — Mauryan Imperial State & Military Structure: Central monarchy, four strategic provincial viceroyalties, and Megasthenes' 6 military sub-committees.

Central and Provincial Administrative Tiers

Historians reconstruct Mauryan governance from three complementary sources: the Greek envoy **Megasthenes' Indica**, Kautilya's statecraft treatise **Arthashastra**, and the monumental **edicts of Ashoka**.

- **Uneven Imperial Reach:** The empire was too vast for uniform direct rule. Direct administration was concentrated around the capital Pataliputra and provincial hubs; peripheral forest regions remained lightly supervised.
- **Four Provincial Centers:**
  - **Taxila:** Controlled the north-western trade routes to Central Asia and the Silk Route.
  - **Ujjayini:** Commanded western trade junctions leading to sea ports in Gujarat.
  - **Tosali:** Guarded coastal Kalinga (modern Odisha).
  - **Suvarnagiri:** Meaning "Golden Mountain", strategically stationed in modern Karnataka to exploit local gold mines.
- **Princely Governors:** These major regional centres were governed by royal princes styled **Kumaras** or **Kumaramatyas**, supported by local councils.

Megasthenes on Military and Municipal Organization

Megasthenes, ambassador from the Hellenistic king Seleucus Nicator to Chandragupta's court, recorded the sophisticated committee system governing Pataliputra and the imperial military:

- **The 30-Member Military Board:** The army was administered by a supreme committee of thirty members, divided into six specialized sub-committees of five members each:
  1. **First Sub-committee:** Maintained the navy and river flotillas.
  2. **Second Sub-committee:** Managed transport, pack-animals, food rations, bullock-carts, and camp servants.
  3. **Third Sub-committee:** Responsible for the foot-soldiers (infantry).
  4. **Fourth Sub-committee:** Maintained the cavalry and horses.
  5. **Fifth Sub-committee:** Oversaw war-chariots.
  6. **Sixth Sub-committee:** Procured, fed, and trained war-elephants.

THE MODERN JOINT LOGISTICS COMMAND

Think of Megasthenes' Second Military Sub-committee like a modern army's Integrated Logistics Corps: without cooks, wagon drivers, forage masters, medical bandage bearers, and smiths to shoe horses, even a million archers cannot advance ten miles. The Mauryan state understood that military victory depends as much on logistics as front-line weaponry.

4. Ashokan Dhamma & Epigraphic Propagation

Following the bloody conquest of Kalinga in his 8th regnal year (c. 261 BCE), Emperor **Ashoka** underwent a profound moral transformation, turning from violent territorial conquest (**digvijaya**) to moral conquest (**dhammavijaya**).

Core Tenets of Ashokan Dhamma

Ashoka did not seek to impose a sectarian dogma or force conversion to Buddhism. Instead, **Dhamma** was formulated as an inclusive universal social ethic:

- **Respect for Elders:** Deep obedience to parents, teachers, and senior relatives.
- **Generosity to Ascetics:** Courteous liberality towards both Brahmanas and Buddhist monks (**samanas**).
- **Humane Treatment of Dependents:** Kindness and justice towards servants, domestic labourers, and slaves.
- **Religious Tolerance:** Restraint in speech, avoiding praise of one's own sect while disparaging another's; recognizing that all sects share core spiritual virtues.
- **Ahimsa:** Strict prohibition of unnecessary slaughter of animals for royal banquets and animal sacrifices.

The Institutional Cadre: Dhamma Mahamattas

To ensure Dhamma was actively taught and practiced rather than remaining a royal wish, Ashoka created a new cadre of high officials in his 14th regnal year:

- **Role of Dhamma Mahamattas:** These special ministers travelled across the empire, inspecting prison conditions, securing release of destitute convicts, distributing imperial charity, and teaching moral conduct to householders and forest tribes alike.
- **Edicts on Stone:** Ashoka inscribed his messages across major public communication routes on smoothed living rocks (**Major and Minor Rock Edicts**) and polished monolithic sandstone pillars (**Pillar Edicts**).

5. New Notions of Kingship: Kushanas, Guptas & Sangam South

In the post-Mauryan centuries, as centralized empire fragmented, rulers across northern, central, and southern India devised new religious strategies to legitimize their sovereign status.

Kushana Divine Kingship

The **Kushanas** (c. 1st century BCE to 3rd century CE), who ruled a vast realm spanning Central Asia, Gandhara, and the Gangetic plains, pioneered direct claims to divine status:

- **Colossal Statues:** Enormous stone statues of Kushana monarchs were installed in royal shrines (**devakulas**), most famously at **Mat near Mathura** in Uttar Pradesh and at **Surkh Kotal** in Afghanistan.
- **Divine Epithets:** Kushana emperors adopted the grandiloquent title **Devaputra**, meaning "son of God", inspired by contemporary Han Chinese emperors styled "Sons of Heaven".
- **Coin Portrayals:** Kushana coins portrayed the king's bust with halos, flames emanating from the shoulders, or emerging from cloud banks, visually assimilating monarchs into the celestial pantheon.

Gupta Rulers and Prashastis

The Guptas (c. 4th to 6th century CE) operated through decentralized networks of subordinate feudal chiefs (**samantas**). To project imperial majesty, court poets composed elaborate eulogies (**prashastis**):

- **The Prayag Prashasti (Allahabad Pillar):** Composed in exquisite classical Sanskrit verse and prose (**champu**) by court poet **Harishena** in honour of Emperor **Samudragupta**.
- **King as God on Earth:** The inscription describes Samudragupta as equal to the gods **Kubera** (wealth), **Varuna** (ocean), **Indra** (heavens), and **Yama** (death), a deity whose compassion matched his military genius.
- **Complex Diplomatic Subjugation:** Samudragupta adopted differentiated policies: he exterminated rulers of Aryavarta and annexed their land, captured and liberated kings of Dakshinapatha (southern India), and demanded personal submission and tribute from forest chiefs and frontier monarchs.

Chiefdoms of Tamilakam (The Far South)

South of the Deccan, in the region known as **Tamilakam** (parts of modern Tamil Nadu, Kerala, and Andhra Pradesh), powerful chiefdoms emerged:

- **The Muventar:** Tamil Sangam anthologies celebrate the three ruling houses: the **Cholas** (Kaveri delta), the **Cheras** (Kerala coast), and the **Pandyas** (Madurai/Vaigai basin).
- **Nature of Chiefs:** Chiefs were not absolute taxation-levying kings; they relied on voluntary gift-giving, shared plundered loot with kinsmen, and patronized wandering bards (**panar**) who sang their praise in Sangam poems.

6. Changing Countryside: Agrarian Tech, Land Grants & Gender

Rural society underwent dramatic economic changes as agriculture pushed into marginal regions and hydraulic works multiplied.

Technological Innovations in Farming

- **Iron Ploughshares:** Heavy iron-tipped ploughs revolutionized cultivation in the rich alluvium of the Ganga and Indus valleys, though light wooden hoes remained dominant in rocky and semi-arid terrain.
- **Paddy Transplantation:** Instead of scattering seed directly, seedlings were nurtured in nursery beds and transplanted by hand into submerged paddy fields. This backbreaking labor multiplied yields but deepened social stratification between landowning **gahapatis** and landless hired laborers.
- **Irrigation Facilities:** Wells, tanks, and monumental canal works were constructed. The most famous hydraulic monument is **Sudarshana Lake** in Kathiawar (Gujarat):
  - Originally constructed by local governors under **Chandragupta Maurya** and **Ashoka**.
  - Ruptured by catastrophic storms and rebuilt without oppressive taxes in the 2nd century CE by the Saka ruler **Rudradaman**, commemorated in a celebrated rock inscription at Junagadh.
  - Repaired again in the 5th century CE under the Gupta emperor **Skandagupta**.

Land Grants (Agrahara) and Women's Property Rights

From the early centuries CE, monarchs began donating land to religious beneficiaries:

- **Agrahara Grants:** Tax-free endowments of land or entire villages bestowed exclusively on Brahmanas. Recipients were exempted from paying royal taxes and permitted to collect customary dues from local peasants.
- **Copper Plate Charters:** Grants were legally ratified on engraved copper plates (**tamrapatra**) held by the donee as proof of ownership.
- **The Case of Prabhavati Gupta:**
  - Daughter of the supreme Gupta emperor **Chandragupta II**, married into the powerful **Vakataka** dynasty of the Deccan.
  - Following her husband's early death, she ruled as queen regent and issued independent royal land grants recorded in the **Danguna copper plate inscription**.
  - According to classical legal texts (**Dharmashastras**), women had no independent property ownership rights. Prabhavati Gupta's executive donations demonstrate that royal women exercised extraordinary legal exceptions not enjoyed by ordinary women.

7. Towns, Trade & Numismatics

Urban networks interconnected the Indian subcontinent with Central Asia, China, and the Mediterranean world.

Categories of Urban Centres

- **Political Capitals:** Pataliputra, Ujjayini, Rajagriha, and Taxila served as administrative nerve centres.
- **Commercial & Port Hubs: Bharuch** (Barygaza) on the western coast, **Tamralipti** on the Bengal delta, and **Arikamedu** (Podouke) in the south traded directly with Rome.
- **Religious Centers:** Mathura, Varanasi, and Gaya thrived on pilgrimage traffic and educational patrons.

Merchant Guilds (Shrenis) & Votive Inscriptions

Artisans and merchants organized themselves into self-governing corporations called **shrenis** (guilds):

- **Guild Operations:** Shrenis procured raw materials in bulk, regulated production standards, fixed market prices, and operated internal banking functions accepting public deposits.
- **Votive Records:** Hundreds of short inscriptions on Buddhist stupa railings at Sanchi, Bharhut, and Amaravati record donations by ivory-carvers, weavers, blacksmiths, and perfumers (**gandhikas**).

Numismatic History: The Evolution of Coins

Coin Category	Issuing Authority	Defining Physical & Economic Feature
Punch-marked Coins	Mahajanapadas & Mauryan state (6th–2nd c. BCE)	Pieces of silver and copper stamped with punches of symbols (sun, tree, crescent, hill); lacked ruler portraits or inscriptions.
Indo-Greek Coins	Bactrian / Indo-Greek kings (2nd c. BCE)	First coins in India to carry royal portraits and bilingual inscriptions in Greek and Kharosthi.
First Gold Coins	Kushana Dynasty (c. 1st c. CE)	Remarkable gold issues minted on the Roman weight standard (≈ 8 grams) to facilitate long-distance Silk Route commerce.
Tribal Coins	Republics like Yaudheyas (c. 1st c. CE)	Copper coins issued by republican clans of Punjab and Haryana depicting the war god Karttikeya.
Pure Gold Dinars	Gupta Dynasty (4th–5th c. CE)	Extraordinarily artistic gold coins depicting monarchs playing lutes (**veena**),

Coin Category	Issuing Authority	Defining Physical & Economic Feature
		hunting lions, or performing the Ashvamedha sacrifice.

8. Decipherment of Early Scripts & Historiographical Limitations

How did 19th-century historians recover the forgotten names of ancient kings?



Figure 2: Figure 2 — Inscriptional Epigraphy: Decipherment process from bilingual Indo-Greek coins to Ashokan edicts, contrasted with five structural limitations of inscriptional evidence.

James Prinsep's Decipherment (1838)

Most Ashokan edicts were written in the **Brahmi** script (the mother of almost all modern Indian scripts) and **Kharosthi** in the north-west:

- **The False Assumption:** Early colonial scholars assumed Ashokan Brahmi was identical to contemporary Devanagari. Decipherment stalled until scholars compared medieval Sanskrit manuscripts backward in time.
- **The Breakthrough:** In **1838**, **James Prinsep**, an assay master at the Calcutta Mint and secretary of the Asiatic Society of Bengal, successfully deciphered Ashokan Brahmi by identifying recurring donor phrases on Sanchi stupa railings: matching the word **danam** (gift) allowed individual consonants and vowels to be fixed.
- **Deciphering Kharosthi:** Kharosthi was deciphered by cross-referencing bilingual coins of Indo-Greek kings containing Greek on the obverse and Kharosthi on the reverse.

- **The "Piyadassi" Identification:** Most edicts did not mention the name Ashoka; they referred to **Devanampiya Piyadassi** ("Beloved of the Gods, of pleasant appearance"). By cross-checking with the ancient Sri Lankan chronicles **Dipavamsa** and **Mahavamsa**, scholars identified Piyadassi as the Mauryan emperor Ashoka. Later edicts at **Maski** and **Gujarra** explicitly confirmed **Devanampiya Asoka**.

Critical Limitations of Epigraphy

Inscriptions are invaluable direct primary sources, but historians treat them with caution:

- **Physical Weathering:** Faintly incised letters have suffered stone abrasion, rain erosion, and breakage, leaving sentences incomplete.
- **Linguistic Ambiguity:** Archaic regional Prakrit expressions carry uncertain idiomatic nuances whose exact meanings remain contested.
- **Elite Perspective:** Inscriptions were commissioned by rulers and wealthy guilds; they present an official, idealized worldview and never record military defeats or social revolts.
- **Silence on Daily Reality:** Everyday life, peasant exploitation, subsistence poverty, and women's labour are totally absent from formal monumental inscriptions.

Key Facts & Terms: One-Stop Revision



Figure 3: Figure 3 — Early States & Economies Topic Summary Mindmap: Complete synthesis of the 6th-century BCE watershed, Mauryan administration, kingship, agrarian economy, coins, and epigraphy.

- **Mahajanapada:** One of the sixteen territorial states that emerged in northern India during the 6th century BCE.
- **Gana / Sangha:** Oligarchic republican state where power was wielded collectively by an assembly of clan elders.

- **Devanampiya:** "Beloved of the gods", royal title adopted by Ashoka and later his grandson Dasharatha.
- **Piyadassi:** "Of pleasant countenance", epithet used in Ashokan edicts.
- **Dhamma Mahamattas:** Special ministerial cadre instituted by Ashoka in his 14th regnal year to propagate Dhamma.
- **Prayag Prashasti:** Classical Sanskrit panegyric inscribed on the Allahabad pillar by Harishena praising Samudragupta.
- **Devaputra:** "Son of God", imperial title adopted by Kushana monarchs claiming divine kinship.
- **Agrahara:** Rent-free land grant gifted by kings to Brahmanas, who were exempt from state taxes.
- **Shreni:** Corporation or guild of merchants and artisans regulating commerce and craft production.
- **Gahapati:** Head of a household who owned, managed, and controlled family land and wealth.

Wrong-Answer Clinic — the one-line corrections

If you answered...	Your slip was...	The corrected rule, in one line
Brahmi was written right to left	Confusing Brahmi with Kharosthi	Brahmi was written from left to right; Kharosthi was written from right to left.
Guptas issued the first gold coins in India	Confusing gold coin quality with first issue	Kushanas issued the first gold coins (c. 1st c. CE); Guptas issued the purest gold coins.
Ashoka's name appears on all his edicts	Assuming universal name usage	Most edicts use the title **Devanampiya Piyadassi**; Ashoka is named in only four edicts (Maski, Gujarra, Nittur, Udegolam).
Punch-marked coins carried ruler portraits	Applying Greek coin norms to indigenous punch-marks	Punch-marked coins carried only punched symbols (hills, trees, animals), never portraits or written names.
Harishena authored the Arthashastra	Mixing court poets with political philosophers	Chanakya (Kautilya) wrote the **Arthashastra**; Harishena wrote the **Prayag Prashasti**.

OurMocks

15 High-Yield CUET Practice Questions

Q1. Which scholar deciphered the ancient Brahmi and Kharosthi scripts in 1838?

(A) Alexander Cunningham
(B) James Prinsep
(C) John Marshall
(D) Mortimer Wheeler

Q2. In which of the following edicts is the personal name 'Ashoka' explicitly inscribed alongside his royal title?

(A) Rummindei Pillar Edict
(B) Maski Minor Rock Edict
(C) Bhabru Rock Edict
(D) Kalinga Rock Edict XIII

Q3. Which dynasty was the first in Indian history to issue gold coins in the 1st century CE?

(A) Mauryan Dynasty
(B) Kushana Dynasty
(C) Gupta Dynasty
(D) Satavahana Dynasty

Q4. According to Megasthenes, how many sub-committees coordinated the overall military administration of the Mauryan Empire?

(A) Four
(B) Five
(C) Six
(D) Eight

Q5. The celebrated Prayag Prashasti (Allahabad Pillar Inscription) was composed in classical Sanskrit by which court poet?

(A) Banabhatta
(B) Harishena
(C) Kalidasa
(D) Ravikirti

Q6. The rock-cut Sudarshana Lake in Gujarat was repaired and restored in the 2nd century CE without imposing taxes by which Saka ruler?

(A) Maues
(B) Chashtana
(C) Rudradaman I
(D) Nahapana

Q7. Prabhavati Gupta, who exceptionally granted land despite Dharmashastric restrictions, was the daughter of which prominent ruler?

(A) Samudragupta
(B) Chandragupta II
(C) Kumaragupta I
(D) Skandagupta

Q8. What was the term used in early historical northern India for a tax-free land grant gifted by kings exclusively to Brahmanas?

(A) Devadana
(B) Agrahara
(C) Brahmadeya
(D) Shasanam

Q9. Which ancient capital city was nicknamed 'the house of the king' and was surrounded by five natural protective hills?

(A) Pataliputra
(B) Rajagriha
(C) Kaushambi
(D) Vaishali

Q10. The Sangam literature refers to the 'Muventar', which designates the ruling heads of which three southern kingdoms?

(A) Cholas, Cheras, Pandyas
(B) Pallavas, Kadambas, Chalukyas
(C) Rashtrakutas, Gangas, Hoysalas
(D) Satavahanas, Ikshvakus, Vakatakas

Q11. What was the name of the special ministerial cadre created by Emperor Ashoka to preach moral ethics across all communities?

(A) Samahartas
(B) Yuktas
(C) Dhamma Mahamattas
(D) Kumaramatyas

Q12. Punch-marked coins, the earliest currency of the Indian subcontinent, were made predominantly of which metals?

(A) Gold and Lead
(B) Silver and Copper
(C) Bronze and Tin
(D) Electrum and Nickel

Q13. Which provincial administrative center of the Mauryan Empire was known as the 'Golden Mountain' due to its proximity to gold mines?

(A) Taxila
(B) Ujjayini
(C) Tosali
(D) Suvarnagiri

Q14. Which ancient text composed by Kautilya provides in-depth guidelines on statecraft, espionage, and taxation?

(A) Indica
(B) Arthashastra
(C) Mudrarakshasa
(D) Manusmriti

Q15. What was a key reason why early epigraphers faced immense difficulties in reconstructing continuous dynastic histories?

(A) Inscriptions were always written in foreign languages
(B) Stones were often eroded and inscriptions recorded only royal viewpoints
(C) No inscriptions survived outside Sri Lanka
(D) Inscriptions never mentioned any calendar dates

Solutions & Detailed Explanations

Sol. Q1. James Prinsep, an officer in the mint of the East India Company and secretary of the Asiatic Society of Bengal, successfully deciphered Ashokan Brahmi in 1838. He deduced the script by matching recurring votive donor terms on Sanchi stupas.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q2. Most Ashokan edicts mention the title **Devanampiya Piyadassi**. The personal name **Ashoka** occurs in only four minor rock edicts: **Maski** (Karnataka), **Gujarra** (Madhya Pradesh), **Nittur**, and **Udegolam**.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q3. The **Kushanas** were the first rulers in the subcontinent to issue gold coins in c. 1st century CE. These were minted on the weight standard of the Roman denarius to support long-distance trade.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q4. Megasthenes explicitly recorded a committee of thirty members coordinating military operations through **six sub-committees** of five members each (Navy, Transport, Infantry, Cavalry, Chariots, Elephants).

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q5. **Harishena**, the court poet and minister (**sandhivigrahika**) of Emperor Samudragupta, composed the **Prayag Prashasti** in ornate Sanskrit **champu** style on the Allahabad pillar.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q6. The Junagadh rock inscription records that the Saka ruler **Rudradaman I** (c. 150 CE) personally funded the reconstruction and embankment repair of Sudarshana Lake out of his own treasury without taxing the populace.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q7. Prabhavati Gupta was the daughter of the Gupta emperor **Chandragupta II** (**Vikramaditya**) and queen Kuberanaga. She married Rudrasena II of the Vakataka dynasty.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q8. An **Agrahara** was a grant of land given to a Brahmana, who was usually exempt from paying land revenue and other dues to the king, and was often given the right to collect these dues from the local people.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q9. Rajagriha (literally "home of the king") was the old capital of Magadha. It was a fortified settlement strategically located amongst five natural hills, before the capital moved to Pataliputra.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q10. The Tamil word **Muventar** translates to "three chiefs", used in Sangam poems to designate the three dynastic chiefdoms of southern India: the **Cholas**, the **Cheras**, and the **Pandyas**.

Answer: (A)

Sol. Q11. In his 14th regnal year, Ashoka instituted the **Dhamma Mahamattas**, dedicated imperial ministers whose specific task was to spread the moral code of Dhamma among all subjects.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q12. The earliest punch-marked coins (c. 6th century BCE onwards) were made of **silver and copper**, stamped with distinct punches of symbols such as hills, trees, and animals.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q13. Suvarnagiri (literally "the golden mountain") in modern Karnataka was selected as a provincial headquarters because of its proximity to the rich Kolar and Hutti gold mining areas.

Answer: (D)

Sol. Q14. The **Arthashastra**, attributed to Chanakya (Kautilya), Chandragupta Maurya's chief minister, is the premier ancient Indian treatise on statecraft, economic policy, and military strategy.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q15. Epigraphy has clear structural limitations: letters are often faintly engraved, stone surfaces get weathered, and inscriptions represent the patronizing, biased perspective of wealthy royal commissioners rather than ordinary people.

Answer: (B)